

Saguinus oedipus

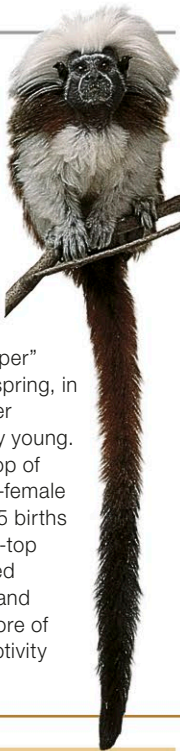
Cotton-top tamarin



Length 8–10 in
(20–25 cm)
Tail 13–16 in
(33–40 cm)
Weight 14–16 oz
(400–450 g)
Social unit Group/Pair
Status Critically endangered



The long, white, flowing fur on the head crown distinguishes this tamarin, found in an extremely restricted range in Colombia. Like many marmosets and tamarins, this species has a varied diet and a “helper” system of rearing offspring, in which males and older siblings carry the very young. However, in each troop of 2–15, only one male–female pair breeds; 4 out of 5 births are twins. The cotton-top tamarin has been used in medical research, and currently there are more of these monkeys in captivity than in the wild.



Mico argentatus

Silvery marmoset



Length 8–9 in
(20–23 cm)
Tail 10–13 in
(26–33 cm)
Weight Up to 14 oz
(400 g)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



Color is the main distinguishing feature among 23 very similar, closely related marmosets from south of the Amazon. This species has pale silver-gray fur on the back, creamy yellow on the underside, and black on the tail; the face has pink skin and ears. In each small troop of silvery marmosets, only one male and female breed. The rest are siblings, cousins, and other “helpers,” who assist in carrying and protecting the infants.



Cebuella pygmaea

Pygmy marmoset



Length 4¼–6 in
(12–15 cm)
Tail 7–9 in
(17–23 cm)
Weight 3–5 oz
(85–140 g)
Social unit Group/Pair
Status Least concern



The smallest monkey in the world, a curled-up pygmy marmoset fits into a human palm. However, it is long-lived for such a diminutive mammal and may reach 12 years of age. The pygmy marmoset differs from other marmosets in the way it eats gum: it gouges out 10 or more new holes in bark each day, scent-marks them, and returns to these and older holes at intervals to scrape up the sticky, oozing liquid with its long, lower incisor teeth. It also takes flower nectar, fruit, and small creatures such as grubs and spiders. The pygmy marmoset follows the reproductive pattern of other marmosets, with one breeding pair per troop of 2–9. Other troop members, usually older offspring, are childcare “helpers,” who carry the 2 newest youngsters after the breeding male has cared for them during the first few weeks.



Callithrix geoffroyi

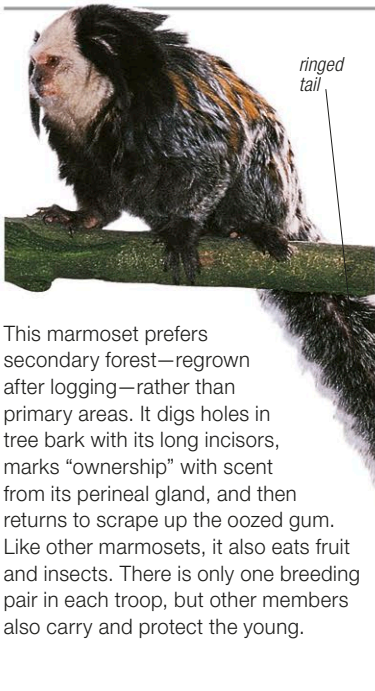
Geoffroy's tufted-ear marmoset



Length 7–9 in
(18–23 cm)
Tail 11½ in (29 cm)
Weight 6¾–13 oz
(190–350 g)
Social unit Group/Pair
Status Least concern



This marmoset prefers secondary forest—regrown after logging—rather than primary areas. It digs holes in tree bark with its long incisors, marks “ownership” with scent from its perineal gland, and then returns to scrape up the oozed gum. Like other marmosets, it also eats fruit and insects. There is only one breeding pair in each troop, but other members also carry and protect the young.



Leontopithecus rosalia

Golden lion tamarin



Length 10–13 in
(26–33 cm)
Tail 12½–16 in
(32–40 cm)
Weight Up to 29 oz
(800 g)
Social unit Group/Pair
Status Endangered



This tamarin weighs twice the average for the marmoset and tamarin group. The face is dark gray and the hands, fingers, and claws are long and thin, to probe into bark and crevices for grubs. However some four-fifths of the diet is fruit, supplemented by gum and nectar. It forages by day and sleeps at night in tangled vegetation or, more often, a hole in a tree. There is only one male–female breeding pair in the troop of 2–11. In its “helper” system of rearing young—2 offspring being typical for the group—sexual activity of the helpers is not suppressed, although they do not produce young until they form the dominant partnership.



LION'S MANE
The long, silky, red-gold head hair of this species cascades over the shoulders in the manner of a lion's mane. Its attractive appearance is a further threat, making it a particular target of the illegal pet trade.

CONSERVATION

An emblem of conservation, the golden lion tamarin comes from Brazil's Atlantic coast forest—a habitat that has shrunk dramatically. Declared endangered over 30 years ago, its status rose to critically endangered in 1996, when less than 300 wild animals remained. Captive breeding programs have proved very successful. In 2008, there were about 1,600 living in the wild, many of which descended from animals raised in captivity. However, with little original habitat left, its future remains precarious.

